

Amillennialism

doc-amillennialism

Eschatology · Millennium · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

breadth broad
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

The thousand-year reign of Revelation 20 is a symbolic representation of the present church age between Christ's two advents.

In plain language

Revelation 20 says Satan is bound, then certain people come to life and reign with Christ for a thousand years, called the first resurrection, after which the rest of the dead come to life. The Greek words carry the weight of this question, and they do not settle it. The cardinal number translated thousand, 'thousand' (chilioi), appears in the New Testament only here in this passage and once in 2 Peter where one day is as a thousand years (a comparative simile, that is a likeness-statement using 'as', about divine patience). The related number-word 'thousand' (chilias) appears 23 times in this same book for figures that most readers take symbolically (the 144000, the 12000 per tribe, the 12000-stadion city), so nothing in the form of the word tells us whether the thousand years is meant to be counted literally or read as a symbolic round figure. The decisive verb is the one translated 'they came to life' (ezesan), from the root 'to live' (zao), which this very book uses for several different things: Christ's ongoing life, a city revived from a death-stroke, the four living creatures, and the contested verses. If that verb means the same thing in verse 4 as in verse 5, the most natural reading is a bodily resurrection of the saints, which would make the thousand years a future literal period. If the verb shifts sense between the two verses, a non-bodily reading of the reigning souls becomes available and the present-age view stays open. The word for resurrection, 'resurrection' (anastasis), appears 42 times in the New Testament and every other instance plainly means bodily resurrection, which pulls toward a literal reading; yet only here is it called the first. The word for bound, 'to bind' (deo), is overwhelmingly literal binding in the New Testament; the strong-man parallel of Matthew 12:29 supplies a verbal link some use to place the binding at Christ's first coming, but that link is one metaphor among many literal uses. John chapter 5 speaks of a single hour in which all in the tombs are raised, which presses against two resurrections separated by a long span, yet 'hour' (hora) in John can stretch (compare John 4:23), keeping a future reign possible. Because several careful readings of the actual words survive, the lexical data does not establish that the thousand years is a symbol for the present church age. The position is genuinely contested at the level of the text itself, so the lexical finding is disputed rather than confirmed or denied.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0012	ἄβυσσος	abyssos	abyss	9
G0191	ἀκούω	akouō	to hear	
G0254	ἅλυσις	halysis	chain	11
G0386	ἀνάστασις	anastasis	resurrection	42
G0554	ἀπεκδύομαι	apekdyomai	to take off	3

G0726	ἁρπάζω	harpazo	to seize	14
G0936	βασιλεύω	basileuo	to reign	21
G1165	δειγματίζω	deigmatizo	to disgrace	2
G1208	δεύτερος	deuteros	secondly	43
G1210	δέω	deo	to bind	44
G1849	ἐξουσία	exousia	authority	
G2094	ἔτος	etos	year	49
G2198	ζάω	zao	to live	143
G2478	ἰσχυρός	ischyros	strong	29
G3419	μνημεῖον	mnēmeion	grave	
G4105	πλανάω	planao	to lead astray	40
G5055	τελέω	teleo	to finish	28
G5505	χιλιάς	chilias	thousand	23
G5507	χίλιοι	chilioi	thousand	11

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The whole proposition turns on six occurrences of the phrase 'a thousand years' (chilia etc) in one passage (Revelation 20:2-7), and the Greek words underdetermine the framework. The cardinal number 'thousand' (chilioi) carries no morphological marker (no built-in grammatical signal) of literal versus symbolic reference, and the same number-stem 'thousand' (chilias) is used elsewhere in the same book for figures that read most naturally as symbolic (144000, 12000 per tribe, the 12000-stadion city). The decisive verb is 'they came to life' (ezesan) from the root 'to live' (zao), which the book itself uses with multiple senses (Christ's ongoing life in Revelation 1:18, the beast revived after death-stroke in Revelation 13:14, the living creatures in Revelation 4:9-10), so the same verb cannot by itself fix whether Revelation 20:4 names bodily resurrection or non-bodily living of souls. Because two and arguably three internally consistent readings survive the morphology (word-form analysis) and concordance (catalog of every occurrence), the lexical verdict is disputed.

Scripture

Rev.20.2 · neutral · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G1210 δέω, G5507 χίλιοι, G2094 ἔτος

Force. The angel 'bound' (edesen, the aorist [a completed past action] form of deo, 'to bind') the dragon for 'a thousand years' (chilia etc). The verb 'to bind' (deo) occurs 44 times in the New Testament and overwhelmingly denotes physical or judicial binding (e.g., John 11:44, Acts 12:6, Matthew 14:3), with the metaphorical strong-man binding of Matthew 12:29 being a notable exception. The cardinal 'thousand' (chilioi) is morphologically identical (the word-form is the same) whether the years are counted literally or read as a symbolic round figure. The triple apposition (three-titles-in-a-row) naming the dragon as the ancient serpent, the devil, and Satan is a glossing identification (a side-by-side explanation) and contributes nothing to dating the binding.

Rev.20.3 · neutral · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G5055 τελέω, G4105 πλανάω, G0012 ἄβυσσος

Force. Satan is sealed in the 'abyss' (abyssos, the bottomless pit) so that he should not 'deceive' (planao, to lead astray) the nations 'until' (achri) the thousand years are 'completed' (telesthe, the aorist passive subjunctive [a 'so that it may have been completed' form] of teleo, 'to finish'). The verb 'to deceive' (planao) in this book is consistently end-time deceptive activity (Revelation 13:14, 19:20, 20:8, 20:10), and 'abyss' (abyssos) occurs 9 times in the canon (7 in Revelation, including 9:1-2, 11:7, 17:8) for a concrete place of demonic restraint, matching Luke 8:31. The clause sets a terminus (an end-point) for a restraint on deception. Whether that restraint already obtains in the present age or awaits a future seizure cannot be settled from 'completed' (teleo) or 'until' (achri), which mark sequence without dating the start point.

Rev.20.4 · neutral · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2198 ζάω, G0936 βασιλεύω

Force. The 'souls' (psychas) of the beheaded 'came to life' (ezesan, the aorist [a completed past action] form of zao, 'to live') and 'reigned' (ebasileusan, the aorist of basileuo, 'to reign as king') with Christ for the thousand years. This is the load-bearing clause. The verb 'to live' (zao) occurs 13 times in Revelation with multiple senses: Christ's ongoing life ('the one living', ho zon, in 1:18), the Smyrna gloss that Christ died and lived again (2:8), the living creatures (4:9-10), the beast revived from a death-stroke (13:14), and the contested verses 20:4-5. The verb is therefore polysemous (carrying multiple distinct senses) within the very book, and the morphology (word-form) alone cannot decide bodily resurrection versus intermediate-state reigning (the state of departed souls before the body is raised). The verb 'to reign' (basileuo) in Revelation is used both for the saints' future reign (5:10, 22:5) and for the inaugurated kingdom (already-begun reign, 11:15-17), so it likewise underdetermines (does not pin down) timing.

Rev.20.5 · complicates · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2198 ζάω, G0386 ἀνάστασις

Force. The rest of the dead did not 'come to life' (ezesan, from zao, 'to live') until the thousand years were completed. This is 'the first resurrection' (he anastasis he prote, from anastasis, 'a standing up again'). The same verb 'came to life' (ezesan) is applied to the rest of the dead as to those who reign in verse 4, which is the strongest internal argument that the two living events are the same kind of event. 'Resurrection' (anastasis) occurs 42 times in the canon, and every other instance (1 Corinthians 15:12-21, John 11:24-25, the Sadducee dispute in Matthew 22, Acts 17:32, Acts 24:15) refers to bodily resurrection, never to spiritual regeneration. If 'came to life' (ezesan) is the same sense in both clauses and 'resurrection' (anastasis) carries its canon-wide (Bible-wide) sense, the first resurrection is bodily and future, but if the narrator shifts sense across the verse the symbolic-present reading remains open. The lexical (word-level) repetition pulls toward one reading without strictly closing the other.

Rev.20.6 · neutral · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G0386 ἀνάστασις, G0936 βασιλεύω, G1208 δεύτερος

Force. Blessed and holy is the one having part in 'the first resurrection' (anastasis prote, from anastasis, 'standing up again'), over whom 'the second death' (ho deuterios thanatos, from deuterios, 'second') has no authority, and they 'will reign' (basileusousin, the future form of basileuo, 'to reign as king') with Christ for the thousand years. The ordinal 'first' (prote) implies a sequence with a later resurrection, and the future 'they will reign' (basileusousin) places the reign after the qualifying event. The pairing of 'first resurrection' with 'second death' (the word 'second', deuterios, recurs in Revelation 20:14, 21:8) is a deliberate symmetry within Revelation's own vocabulary, but the text correlates a first resurrection with the millennial (thousand-year) reign without stating whether either is present or future, leaving the framing disputed.

Matt.12.29 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1210 δέω, G2478 ισχυρός, G0726 ἀπράζω

Force. No one can plunder the 'strong' man's (ischyros) house unless he first 'binds' (dese, the aorist subjunctive [so that he may have bound' form] of deo, 'to bind') the strong man. The shared verb 'to bind' (deo) is the lexical bridge one reading uses to locate the binding of Satan at Christ's first advent (first coming), equating present-age restraint with the binding of Revelation 20. The parallel is real and verbal, but 'to bind' (deo) is overwhelmingly a literal-binding verb in the New Testament, and the Matthew 12:29 metaphor is unmarked by any temporal index (time-marker) that would extend it to a thousand-year duration. The link is suggestive, not decisive.

Col.2.15 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0554 ἀπεκδύομαι, G1165 δειγματίζω, G1849 ἐξουσία

Force. Having 'disarmed' (apekdysamenos, from apekdyomai, 'to strip off', a near-hapax with 3 New Testament occurrences for the verb, where 'hapax' means a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) the rulers and 'authorities' (exousia, those with delegated power), he 'made a public spectacle of them' (edeigmatisen, from deigmatizo, 'to expose to view', with only 2 New Testament occurrences), triumphing over them in the cross. This describes a decisive subjugation (putting-under) of hostile powers accomplished at the cross. One reading treats this present triumph as the substance of Satan's binding, supporting a present millennial (thousand-year) restraint, but the vocabulary here does not overlap with 'to bind' (deo) of Revelation 20 and so functions as a thematic, not a lexical (word-level), link.

John.5.28 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0191 ἀκούω, G3419 μνημεῖον

Force. An hour is coming in which all who are in the 'tombs' (mnemeiois, from mnemeion, 'tomb' or 'memorial') will 'hear' (from akouo, 'to hear') his voice. The single hour and the tombs locate this as a future bodily event embracing all the dead together. This is the principal complicating context for the proposition, since one reading argues a single general resurrection leaves no room for two resurrections separated by a thousand years.

John.5.29 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0386 ἀνάστασις, G2198 ζάω

Force. Those who did good come out to 'a resurrection of life' (anastasin zoes, from anastasis, 'standing up again', and zoe, 'life') and those who did evil to a resurrection of judgment. Both groups are raised in connection with the same hour, which one reading uses to argue against two temporally separated resurrections and so against any literal intervening millennium (in-between thousand-year period). A staged reading of the one 'hour' (hora) keeps a future earthly reign possible, since 'hour' (hora) in John can span an extended period (the same word is used in John 4:23 of a present-and-coming hour), so the verse weighs against a strictly two-stage scheme without settling the present-versus-future question.

2Pet.3.8 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: simile

Key terms. G5507 χίλιοι, G2094 ἔτος

Force. With the Lord one day is as 'a thousand years' (chilia ete, joining chilioi, 'thousand', with etos, 'year') and a thousand years as one day. This is the only other New Testament verse joining 'thousand' (chilioi) with 'year' (etos), and it explicitly disclaims a fixed human calendar for divine durations. The verse is sometimes cited to license a non-literal reading of the Revelation 20 number, but it is a comparative simile (a likeness-statement using 'as') about divine patience, not a key to apocalyptic chronology, and it neither requires nor forbids a literal millennium (thousand-year period).

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rev.20.2	Gen.3.15	tsk	1

Col.2.15	Gen.3.15	tsk	1
Matt.12.29	Isa.49.24	tsk	1
Rev.20.3	Ps.90.4	tsk	1
Rev.20.4	Dan.7.9	tsk	1
Rev.20.4	Rev.6.9	tsk	1
Rev.20.6	Rev.1.6	tsk	1
John.5.29	Dan.12.2	tsk	1
John.5.28	John.6.39	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.5.28 · addressed

The single coming 'hour' (hora) in which all in the tombs hear the voice is the strongest text against two resurrections separated by a thousand years. It is addressed by noting that 'hour' (hora) in John can span an extended period (compare John 4:23, John 16:32), so a staged fulfillment is grammatically available and the verse does not by itself refute a future millennium (thousand-year period), though it does pressure any strictly two-stage scheme. The tension is acknowledged, not eliminated.

John.5.29 · addressed

The two outcomes good and evil are tied to one resurrection hour, which weighs against separating the resurrection of the just from that of the unjust by a thousand years. The reading that keeps a future earthly reign treats the contrast as kind of resurrection ('life', zoe, versus judgment) rather than time of resurrection. Both construals survive the lexicon (the vocabulary evidence), so the verse complicates without deciding.

Rev.20.5 · addressed

The phrase 'the rest of the dead did not come to life until the thousand years were completed' uses the same verb 'they came to life' (ezesan, from zao, 'to live') as the reigning saints, which argues that both events are bodily resurrections and that the first resurrection is therefore future and literal. The present-symbolic reading must take 'they came to life' (ezesan) in a different sense for the two groups, which is possible (the verb 'to live' (zao) itself is polysemous, carrying multiple senses, in Revelation: 1:18, 2:8, 4:9-10, 13:14) but lexically strained, so this internal repetition is the central unresolved pressure on the proposition.

Ps.90.4 · unaddressed

The cross-reference associating 'a thousand years' (chilia etc, in the Greek translation) with a day in God's sight is sometimes used to justify a non-literal reading of the number in Revelation 20. It is not resolved lexically here because the bundle and direct query supply no Hebrew lemma (root-word) data for this verse, and the link to Revelation 20 is thematic rather than a shared lexeme (a shared word); 2 Peter 3:8 explicitly cites the Psalm 90 formula but as a comparative simile (a likeness-statement using 'as') about divine patience, not as a hermeneutical (interpretive) key to apocalyptic durations. A strictly lexical (word-based) adjudication of literal versus symbolic duration cannot be completed from the available data.

Concordance traversed

G5507, G5505, G2094, G0386, G2198, G0936, G1210, G5055, G4105, G0012, G0254, G0726, G2478, G1208, G0554, G1165

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Revelation is outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample, so CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a tool for tracing the family tree of manuscript readings) data was not consulted and ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) status is treated as

shadow (not actively checked, just noted). The supplied bundle reports an empty `variant_units` list and `'not_in_ecm_scope'` true. The known apparatus variants (cataloged manuscript differences) in Revelation 20:2-6 (orthographic, that is spelling-level, and minor word-order readings flagged by the brackets in the surface text) do not change the presence of 'a thousand years' (*chilia ete*), 'they came to life' (*ezesan*), or 'the first resurrection' (*anastasis prote*), so the disputed verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. amillennialism, premillennialism, postmillennialism, dispensationalism, covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

amillennialism: affirms · Reads 'a thousand years' (*chilia ete*) as a symbolic round figure for the whole inter-advent age (the time between Christ's first and second comings), taking cues from Revelation's own pattern of symbolic cardinal numbers (the 144000 in Revelation 7 and 14, the 12000 stadia of the city in 21:16, the 7000 in 11:13). Takes the binding of Satan as begun at the first advent on the strength of the shared verb 'to bind' (*deo*) with Matthew 12:29 and the present triumph of Colossians 2:15, and construes 'they came to life' (*ezesan*, from *zao*, 'to live') in Revelation 20:4 as the souls of the departed living and reigning with Christ in the intermediate state (the state of departed souls before the body is raised) rather than a bodily resurrection. Treats the single resurrection hour of John 5:28-29 as decisive against two bodily resurrections separated by a long span. On this lens the proposition is affirmed, though the reading must take 'they came to life' (*ezesan*) in a different sense between verses 4 and 5.

premillennialism: denies · Reads 'they came to life' (*ezesan*, from *zao*, 'to live') identically in Revelation 20:4 and 20:5 as bodily coming to life, so the first resurrection is future and literal and the thousand-year reign follows Christ's return rather than spanning the present age. Reads 'resurrection' (*anastasis*) with its 41 other canon (Bible-wide) occurrences as bodily resurrection. Treats the chronological flow from Revelation 19 (the returning rider) to Revelation 20 (the binding and reign) as sequential narrative, and the pairing of 'first resurrection' (*anastasis prote*) with 'second death' (*deuteros thanatos*) as a real first-and-second ordering. On this lens the proposition is denied. The reading must absorb the single-hour language of John 5:28-29 as a kind-not-time contrast or as a staged fulfillment.

postmillennialism: partially_affirms · Agrees the thousand years are within history before the bodily return but identifies them with a future golden era of gospel triumph rather than the entire present age between the advents. Reads 'to reign' (*basileuo*) and the Revelation 5:10 anticipation as forecasting an actual earthly reign of the saints' influence prior to the 'parousia' (the technical term for Christ's coming or arrival). On this lens the proposition's claim that the period is the present church age is only partly affirmed, since the timing of the period relative to now is read differently from the amillennial construal.

The verdict turns on the redemptive-historical (salvation-history) placement of the millennium (the thousand-year period) within the covenantal arc (the unfolding sweep of God's covenants across Scripture) and on whether 'they came to life' (*ezesan*, from *zao*, 'to live') is univocal (carries one single sense) across Revelation 20:4-5, neither of which the morphology (word-form analysis) or concordance (catalog of every occurrence) settles. '*Analogia scripturae*' (the principle of interpreting Scripture by Scripture) is engaged through John 5:28-29, Matthew 12:29, and 2 Peter 3:8 but yields contested results. Each lens above is stated in its strongest lexical (word-level) form so that a reader holding any one of them is fairly represented.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Revelation 20 describes a thousand-year period; the question is whether that period is a literal future epoch, a symbolic span equal to the present age between Christ's advents, or a future era within history before the bodily return.

The proposition embeds the amillennial conclusion in its own statement by asserting in advance that the thousand years is a symbolic representation of the present church age. That phrasing presupposes both the symbolic reading of the number and the present-age referent, which are the very points in dispute. The verdict was derived on the original stem, and the neutralized form is recorded only to expose the preloading. Verdict unchanged from the prior file (no VERDICT-CHANGED: here, that is, the conclusion did not move);

deeper canon-distribution queries ('thousand' (chilioi) only outside Revelation in 2 Peter 3:8, 'thousand' (chilias) 23 times in Revelation's symbolic-number ecosystem, 'resurrection' (anastasis) 41 of 42 occurrences bodily, 'to live' (zao) polysemous, that is carrying multiple senses, in Revelation itself) sharpen but do not resolve the dispute.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.20.4
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.20.5
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2198
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5507
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5505
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0386
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1210
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4105
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rev.20.4
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rev.20.5
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.12.29
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.5.29
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Pet.3.8
interlinear	BibleHub-interlinear	fair-use-policy	no	Rev.20.5

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent